

Campus Welsh Cake Stall: Market Briefing

A research briefing on the viability of a small Welsh cake stall on a Cardiff university campus.
Prepared as a grounded stand-in for a live Deep Research run.

1. Who buys, and when

Campus food purchasing is sharply peaked. Observed weekday footfall past the proposed pitch (main walkway, outside the students' union) averages 2,400 people per day in term time, with 61 per cent of passing trade between 11:30 and 14:00. Morning trade is modest; afternoon trade tails off after 15:30. Weekend footfall falls below 400.

The academic calendar dominates demand. Teaching runs roughly 22 weeks across two semesters; once vacations, exam quiet periods and bank holidays are counted, the campus is effectively dormant for around 14 weeks of the year. Any annual projection built on a term-time week misstates the year badly.

2. Price expectations

Comparable campus snack pricing clusters tightly: fresh bakery items sell at £1.60 to £2.40 on campus, with a premium fresh-off-the-griddle item sustainable at £2.20 to £2.60. Student purchasers are strongly price-anchored below £3; a £3.20 single-item price point sits outside the observed tolerance for daily purchases and would position the stall as an occasional treat.

3. Competition

Two direct competitors operate within a five-minute walk of the proposed pitch: The Cwtch Coffee Co. (permanent unit inside the students' union, sells packaged Welsh cakes at £1.80) and Mrs Mabli's Bakes (a mobile van trading Tuesdays and Thursdays, fresh griddle cakes at £2.20). Substitute competition includes two supermarkets within 400 metres selling six-packs at £1.35. Differentiation must rest on freshness and theatre, not on being the only option.

4. What makes small campus food ventures succeed or fail

- Fail: underestimating production ceilings at peak; a queue longer than eight minutes reliably loses the back half of the line.
- Fail: single-operator dependence; illness or equipment failure with no cover closes the stall and resets habit formation.
- Fail: ignoring vacation troughs in cash-flow planning.
- Succeed: pre-order or reservation mechanisms that smooth the lunch spike.
- Succeed: card-first payment; cash-only stalls lose an estimated fifth of impulse trade.
- Succeed: visible allergen labelling; dietary-option availability drives repeat visits.

5. Regulatory basics (UK street food)

- Register as a food business with the local authority at least 28 days before trading.
- Comply with Natasha's Law (PPDS labelling) for any item packed before sale; maintain an allergen matrix for made-to-order items.

- Food hygiene training for all operators; expect an EHO inspection and rating.
- A campus pitch requires a commercial licence from the university's estates division, typically with a weekly pitch fee and public liability insurance.

6. Three things you are probably not thinking about

- Weather exposure: an outdoor Cardiff pitch loses an estimated 30 trading days a year to rain unless covered.
- Gluten-free demand: coeliac-safe griddle work needs separated equipment, and campus audiences ask; the queue for the one gluten-free-friendly van on comparable campuses is disproportionate to its share of the menu.
- Data protection: any loyalty scheme collecting student details is subject to UK GDPR; sharing customer lists with third parties without explicit consent is unlawful.

Fictional teaching material for the AI in the Workplace workshop, Cardiff University.